

than the foster parent's own eggs, and then proceeds to throw out the eggs (or smaller chicks if they hatch) in order to minimise the competition for food. This is done purely by instinct as the chick is too young to learn this behaviour. Thus, the cuckoo could possibly be an example of troll-like behaviour (in a broad definition) actually being an obvious evolutionary advantage!

Another mischievous creature we want to highlight here is the Scorpionfly. This weird insect does a lot of strange things in order to mate. The custom for the Scorpionfly mating ritual is for the male to bring the female a gift of food in order

internet forums can draw a parallel here... trust us, there are no women on there, just some men pretending to be women in order to get attention and troll.

If we want to get closer to mankind genetically, there's always monkeys to look at. Anyone who's been to a tourist spot that has monkeys in India will testify to them being really mischievous – and not just with humans, but with other monkeys and other species as well. We've all seen monkeys harass cats, dogs, birds and humans, and they don't always do it for food. Sometimes a bored monkey will steal something inedible purely for fun –

the best word to describe it is “play”. How many of you have watched kids be “mean” to one another when playing? Of course the definition of mean is applied by adult (or more mature) standards here, so if you were to trip someone who is walking by you in a park, then proceed to jump on him/her playfully, pull their hair, throw sand in their face, then run away screaming in laughter, anyone witnessing this would certainly think you were quite an a\$\$hole! When toddlers do it, it's just “playing”. This holds true for all species that we usually observe in domestic situations – kittens, puppies, chicks, foals, cubs...

In biologist terminology, play is something that animals do for fun when they're not stressed, not being hunted or in any other life and death scenario. Many animals can play alone too, because it seems to be a fun state of mind rather than necessitating an interaction with another. However, most popular play methods do involve siblings or other young ones, or even adults. Species can even inter-play, as kittens are often seen playing with puppies, for example. This is not only limited to youngsters, because young adults also exhibit this behaviour, and in fact in many species, this is an all through life method of having some fun.

So can we say that trolling is basically just another method of playing? Perhaps, but we certainly cannot prove it, merely point in that general direction. Perhaps some scientists will make it a study and get a grant to do so and answer that question someday (if some obscure study hasn't already done so).

COMEDY, SATIRE, ETC

When it comes to playing, trolling or basically having fun (often at another's expense), there are many more methods of getting a laugh. Although no concrete data that we could find, there are many suggestions that humour in general is an indicator of good genes.

Thus, think of it in terms of natural selection, and you might find a study or two that suggest that humour is a desirable trait for females when they are



Meet the scorpionfly – the lazy transvestite!

to make her more likely to mate with it. However, males don't always want to work hard to get the meal, and have been known to steal already dead insects from spider-webs, and also steal from other males. However, some of these little male insects take to trolling their counterparts, by pretending to be female, and waiting for some unsuspecting male to bring it food as an offering, which it accepts, and then goes off to find a female to offer the food to. We can only assume there have been a few times when a bunch of males exhibiting this transvestite behaviour just keep regifting food to one another because everyone's pretending to be female. Most

ask the many tourists who didn't secure their cameras with straps, or didn't hold on to their hats!

WHY DO TROLLS STILL EXIST?

If we accept as a hypothesis that trolling (or purposefully mischievous behaviour) is something that's genetic, we then have to wonder why this has survived? What could the evolutionary advantage be for such behaviour to continue?

We think the first and foremost reason for this behaviour existing, especially in younger beings (children, teens, infants), is that it's not really trolling at all. In fact,